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ANN ARBOR MINERAL SPRINGS

[illegible]

WILLIAM W. NICHOLS, DENTIST!

[illegible]

THE AYMERS.

CHAPTER XIV.

[illegible]

How about Count's school?

It was done—had been done two weeks. It was almost September.

[illegible]

SELIM.

[illegible]

FOREIGN CORRESPONDENCE.

Number LXXVI.

TAKAO, FORMOSA, January 2d, 1874.

I had brought letters to the Rev. Mr. Makay, a missionary sent out by the Canadian Presbyterians, who has his headquarters at Tamsui, and I went to his house immediately upon landing, following through the dark, narrow streets of the Chinese town for quite a distance. I did not find Mr. Makay at home; but three or four young men—Chinese—who were studying with the expectation of becoming helpers in the mission, received me very kindly, and did their best to make me comfortable. It was already so cool, that a fire they built of Kelang coal seemed very pleasant, and a few American papers that I found lying about added to the pleasure of again getting out within reach of civilization.

The next morning—Sunday—I went up the river in a small boat to Bangkokee, where I found Mr. Makay at one of the stations he has opened, and the little chapel was very well filled with quiet listeners. In the afternoon we visited another station a few miles away in the same valley, which is one of the richest I ever saw, the rice being just now harvested. We passed through fine avenues of bamboos with orange groves, and there were a few fields of wheat, the first I have seen upon the island, just beginning to ripen. The worshipers at the second chapel, like those at the first, were all Chinese, being mostly independent farmers, owning the rich rice fields about them.

Mr. Makay has now two stations north, near Owlan among the Pepowhan, and three in this valley, near Tamsui, with a fourth in process of erection, the work spreading faster than he can well attend to it. The chapels are built by the people themselves, who throw away their idols and tablets, and ask for a teacher from the mission. Mr. Makay has been from home but two years, and in that time has learned sufficient Chinese to teach the people and preach to them, preaching his first sermon nine months after his arrival, and he now has over two hundred regular worshipers, and other places opening up before him continually.

Formosa seems just now especially open to missionary work, and there are reasons why the people of the island should be more easily influenced by Christian teaching than those of the main land. They are emigrants who have, to a great extent, left behind them those peculiar surroundings that make them so difficult of approach in China proper, such as temples, family clans, etc.

Mr. Makay is an old school teacher, and beside training the young men now studying with him in theology and the Christian religion, he is trying to teach them something of the elements of that scientific knowledge to which European nations owe their power, and the walls were hung with maps that, for lack of better, Mr. Makay had drawn from memory, and with diagrams showing the cause of eclipses, etc. They all showed commendable zeal in their studies, in one case sitting up all night, that they might copy some elementary work of science. Chinese education seems to consist almost wholly in learning a great number of thousands of characters, and committing to memory the sayings of their sages, so that a student, who has received his degrees and is considered fit for the highest positions in the land, is absolutely ignorant of geography, arithmetic and history. The Chinese maps that are now in circulation show China in the center, with a few little dots and specks about the borders, where the barbarians are supposed to live. In spite of all this ignorance, the *literati* of China look with supreme disdain upon Europeans and European learning, and they seem to be the class that are keeping their country from sharing in modern improvements.

I spent a few days in Tamsui packing the collections I had made in the interior of the island, and in putting them on board a tea ship which I found there fortunately, loading direct for New York, and then set out up the river to Kelung. The boats used for this business are long and narrow and very light, that they may be easily lifted over the rapids. We started at midnight, but as the officers of the Chinese customs had kindly furnished me their boat, I slept until morning, when we were near the foot of the rapids. The scenery through which we passed was quite pretty, the country being too mountainous for much cultivation, though the most of the timber had been cut off.

There are a great many rapids in the little river, and when we came to one of these the boatmen would jump into the water, and by a large bamboo lashed across the boat fairly lift it over the rapids, and carry it up stream to where the water was quieter, when they would again take to their poles. Boats of the same class loaded with coal were dashing past us frequently, on their way down, and the rushing of the water and the cries and noise of the boatmen made quite an exciting scene. No people but Chinese would even think of navigating a river that has twenty rapids within ten miles.

Late in the afternoon we found ourselves at the end of the river, among quite a fleet of boats loading with coal, and within two or three miles of Kelung, the river almost making a smaller island of this end of Formosa. A few minutes' climbing up a steep hill side covered with many species of ferns brought us to the top, where there was a pretty little joss house among some banyan trees, from which we could get a good view of Kelung and its pretty harbor, with the great jagged rock called Kelung island beyond. The foreigners in Kelung do not number half a dozen all told, and they have built upon the south side of the harbor, and near that part of it now used as an anchorage, while the Chinese town is situated among mud flats at the upper end of the harbor, where there may have been anchorage a few years ago, for nearly all the harbors of Formosa seem to be rapidly filling up, and, perhaps, this effect is increased by a gradual rising of the land. This seems more reasonable at Kelung, as upon palm island, at the entrance of the harbor there are ledges of coral, that seem to be of no very ancient origin, that are now entirely above water.

Through the kindness of Messrs. Titushkin & Land, of the Chinese customs, I received much assistance in collecting, and set about visiting the different fishing villages about the harbor, inquiring for shells, coral, etc. The little Chinese boys had generally a store of such things, and there would quite a crowd gather about me, each with his basket or a joint of bamboo to serve for one, filled with shells, most of them worn and worthless; but there were enough of value to pay for examining them all, and I spent hours in sorting over these collections, and in paying them in the curious Chinese copper cash. In the shallower parts of the harbor we passed over beds of living coral, of many different species and colors, with schools of bright-colored fish swimming about them. The Chinese finding that I was interested in this, began diving and tearing off these masses of coral and bringing them up, and I soon had quite a trade opened in coral, there being three boat loads at once waiting at the landing to be bought. I kept buying until I had the verandah of the custom house full and my room beside, getting about twenty species in all. Many beautiful fish, crustaceans and shells also dropped from the coral, and were added to my collections.

Just before leaving, I made a trip to Coal harbor, a few miles south of Kelung, about which most of the coal is procured, though the hills all about Kelung have coal, also. The hills of loose sandstone are cut up with ravines, and in these the seams of coal appear. They are worked entirely by Chinese, who lay out very little capital in the business, running in holes that look like fox holes, too small for a person to stand up in, and when these fill with water they are abandoned and new mines opened. The coal is carried out to the entrance of the mines in baskets, or in a sort of boat that slides in the water and mud along the bottom of the mine, and then it is carried in the usual way in baskets to the port, sometimes for a distance of several miles. We met great numbers of coolies stripped nearly naked, and toiling along under loads enough for a mule. There seems to be great abundance of coal, and it is probably all near enough the surface to be easily worked. The coal is of very good quality; but it is said to burn too fast to be economical for steamers when used alone.

Having done about all that was possible for me to do at Kelung, I packed up and went back to Tamsui, getting there in time to send these collections by the tea ship upon which I had shipped the first. I made several trips about Tamsui with Mr. Makay, visiting some large tea plantations, the tea being planted upon the hills, where rice can not be grown for lack of water. The tea plant, from continual picking, is kept down to a low, thick bush from two to four feet high, and it is planted in rows about three feet apart each way. The leaves are a very dark green, and those plantations that are in a flourishing state are beautiful, the plants having the large white, fragrant flowers scattered over them. Only the young leaves, just as they are opening, are picked, but I was too late to see the method.

We also visited the sulphur springs, one of the natural curiosities of the place, which are nine or ten miles distant, and it requires considerable climbing to reach them. They are in a valley several hundred feet above the river below, and the vegetation for quite a distance about is killed by the noxious vapors that arise. The springs cover an acre or more, some of them being blow holes, where hot steam rushes out with such force as to blow stones as large as walnuts into the air; others are hot water springs, the water bubbling up and flowing off at boiling heat. Large amounts of pure sulphur are deposited about these springs, and the ground all about, which is smoking and steaming, is filled with it. The Chinese have manufactured sulphur here at some time, and large quantities of slag from their kettles lay about. We passed down along the stream flowing from these springs, and through large fields of pine apples, which were, unfortunately, now out of bearing. Formosa is noted for this fruit, and it is sent as far as Hongkong. Over half a mile below the springs the stream, now ten or twelve feet across and three or four deep, was steaming, and too hot for comfort at first; but after being in it a few moments it became delightful, and it was more pleasant from a cold wind blowing at the time. The water is most highly charged with mineral matter, and a mouthful of it almost strangled me. The Europeans have used it for bathing, with good results; but I think no one has analyzed the water yet. If it proves to be of value, its great abundance and its temperature are items of consideration, for all the European population of China could find a water cure here.

Christmas found me still at Tamsui, and Mr. Makay and I were invited with the rest of the foreigners to a genuine English Christmas dinner at the house of Mr. Dodd, one of the merchants there, there being plum-puddings, roast beef and turkey, and all the other good things that remind us of home in these far off lands.

Another stormy passage down the channel, and another few hours of sea sickness; but with the consolation of company,—as there were several passengers on board, on their way to Amoy,—and we all took our turn at feeding the fish,—brought us to this port again, after three months' absence.

J. B. STEERE.

A STRANGE STORY.

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